Bukhari Chancery Persian Textbook Development

gerunds_auxiliary_verbs

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Grammatical Explanation

Central Asian Persian documents routinely string several clauses together with past participles used as gerunds (کرده, 'having done'; شده, 'having become'), so that a long sentence may contain only one finite verb, at its very end: آدمان میگذشته گی را تحقیق کرده پرسیده … معلوم مینماید, 'having examined and questioned the people passing through … they report'. The reader's first task is therefore to find that verb, and then to work back through the chain, keeping track of who is doing what: the subject can change from one link to the next without any signal. The end of the chain matters for another reason too: an auxiliary verb or a tense on the final verb usually (but not always) applies to every link before it. It often pays to read the end of a chain first.

The device itself is not foreign to Persian. Classical and early modern prose, including Safavid and Qajar chancery writing, uses it, and formal written Persian in Iran still does (وزیر به تهران رفته، با رئیس‌جمهور دیدار کرد, 'the minister went to Tehran and met the president'), although spoken Persian avoids it. What distinguishes the Central Asian documents is how far they take it: the chains

are longer, the links are seldom joined by و, and the gerund takes on functions it rarely has elsewhere.

- *LS: Is this example sentence correct?*

In this regard Central Asian Persian resembles Turki, where the gerund in -ib (Uyghur ىپ) does the same work: u kelib, xatni o'qidi / ئۇ كېلىپ خەتنى ئوقۇدى, '(s)he came and read the letter'.

The same gerund also combines with auxiliary verbs: the initial gerund defines the action, and the second, auxiliary verb (which can be in any conjugation) determines the valence of the verby, subtly changing the meaning. This construction is far more widespread in Turki than in Persian, both in terms of the number of potential auxiliary verbs and frequency of use.

The most frequent auxiliary in Central Asian Persian documents is ایستادن ('to stand'; also spelled استادن, even within the same document), which after a gerund forms a continuous tense: کرده ایستاده است, '(s)he is doing'. Modern Tajik has the same form (карда истодааст), and Turki follows the same logic, with the verb 'to stand' after the -ib gerund (Uzbek yozib turadi, '(s)he is writing'). With a verb of activity, it describes an action in progress: خبرداری نموده ایستاده ایم, 'we are keeping watch'. In the past, ایستاده بود describes an action in progress when something else happened: سوخته ایستاده بود که …, '[it] was burning when …'.

The gerund گفته ('saying') deserves particular attention, because it works much as Uzbek deb does: it closes a quotation, and the verb that follows shows what the quotation is doing. Like deb, گفته can in principle be used to literally mean 'saying,' and frequently indicates reported speech, but just as often (if not more so) translates to something closer to 'that' in English. For instance, most petitions ends with معلوم شود گفته عرض بنده گی نمودم, literally 'saying "let it be known", I have made [this] petition', that is, 'I submit this so that it may be known'. Thus, when you meet گفته in the middle of a sentence, then, look back for the quotation. Again, however, not every گفته is of this kind: گفته است and گفته بود are ordinary forms of 'to say'.

Several other verbs lose their own meaning after a gerund in the same way, each matching an Uzbek auxiliary after -ib. گشتن ('to walk about') marks repeated or ongoing action (زده گشته, 'goes around beating'; Uzbek -ib yurmoq); ماندن ('to leave') puts something into a state (حبس کرده ماندند, 'they locked him up'; -ib qo'ymoq); رفتن marks action away from the scene, or completed (گریخته رفته اند, 'they fled'; -ib ketmoq); آمدن marks action toward the speaker, or continuing up to the present (جاری شده آمده گی, 'which has been in force [since ancient times]'; -ib kelmoq); دادن marks action done for someone else (خط هم کرده میدهم, 'I will also write [you] a document'; -ib bermoq); and نشستن marks a settled, ongoing state (دوکانداری کرده نشسته است, 'he keeps a shop'; -ib o'tirmoq). Auxiliaries can also be stacked: کوچیده آمده استاده اند, '[they] have moved back and are staying'.

Ability is expressed the same way, with توانستن after the gerund: از ترس آمده نتوانسته, 'out of fear they could not come'. Iranian Persian puts توانستن first and follows it with a subjunctive (نمی‌توانم بیایم, 'I cannot come'). The documents put the gerund first, in the Turki order (Uzbek kela olmadim, 'I could not come').

?Often it is difficult to fully disentangle a verb's auxiliary functionality from its sequential functionality. In رفته استاده, for instance, said of guards sent to a border crossing, استادن may keep its full meaning ('they went and took up their post') or act as the auxiliary described above ('they went and stayed there', like Uzbek borib turib). As in Turki, these ambiguities must be resolved contextually

Examples

> bukh: بکاگان **آمده** جناب قاسم مقام را **دیده** تعینات ایلچی خانه را **شنیده** بعرابه آتشی **سوار** شده ...

> uzb:

> fars:

> eng: **Having come** to Kagan, **seen** the deputy, **heard** the Residency's instructions, and **boarded** the train …

Comments:

> A simple chain: four gerunds with the same subject, the investigator writing the report, and no conjunctions between them.

> Translating these sentences into ideomatic English (whether formally or in one's head while reading) often requires the reader to interpolate conjunctions and sentence breaks that do not appear in the original.

> عرابه آتشی, literally 'fire-cart', refers to a train.

bukh: **سوخته ایستاده بود که** بیگاه یکشنبه ساعت نه بالا خانه عبد الخالق بای شهری **فرستاده** غلامشان ملا خالمراد بی سر کرده فوراً یوزه باشیها را مع تخمینا یکصد نفر سرباز به نیم ساعت **جمع شده** فقرایان گذر اطراف **گرفته آمده** غلامانشان سر بازیه تش و بیل و تبر کمتر بالا خانه مذکوررا …

uzb:

fars:

eng: On Sunday evening at nine o'clock, the upper room of ʿAbd al-Khaliq Bay's house **was burning when** Mulla Khalmurad Bi immediately **sent** the yūzbāshīs with about a hundred soldiers; the soldiers **took** axes, spades and hatchets and **came** ; the people of the surrounding quarter **gathered** , and in less than half an hour [put out] the upper room …

Comments:

> Four subjects in one sentence: the upper room, Mulla Khalmurad Bi, the soldiers, and the people of the quarter. Nothing marks the changes; the reader has to infer them from the verbs (an official sends soldiers; soldiers take up tools).

> The sentence opens with the past continuous سوخته ایستاده بود که, 'was burning when'.

> bukh: … خِرمَن و غیر زراعت هشان مال **رفته** چهار پنج سال باز عاملان خراج اینولایت **سپاریده گشته بوده اند** بدولتخانه چنده **گرفته نموده**

> uzb:

> fars:

> eng: For four or five years the tax collectors of this province **have [reportedly] been going** , assessing their harvests and other crops, collecting levies, and handing them over to the government.

Comments:

> The auxiliary گشته (repeated action) and the non-witnessed بوده اند appear only on the last link of the chain, yet they apply to every link: the collectors have repeatedly gone, assessed, collected and handed over. Read the end of a chain first.

> On بوده اند, see chapter [[]].

> bukh: عرض بنده گی **گفته** بجنابصاحب معلوم شود

> uzb:

> fars:

> eng: This petition of servitude **(is so that)** my lord may be informed.

Comments:

> The closing formula of most petitions: literally 'saying "let it be known to my lord", [this is] a petition of servitude'. گفته turns the wish into a purpose: 'so that it may be known'.

> bukh: مرحمت و مهربانی نمودند **گفته** بتفصیل خط کرده معلوم نمایند

> uzb:

> fars:

> eng: They kindly [instructed] **that** [we] report in detail in writing.

Comments:

> The instruction keeps its original wording (معلوم نمایند, 'let [them] report'), closed by گفته. The verb that follows (مرحمت و مهربانی نمودند, 'they were so kind as to') shows that the words are a superior's instruction. Translate as indirect speech, 'that we should report', but parse as direct speech.

> bukh: مایان میگویند **که** جمعیت بسیار هستیم نوراتا را نیز میتازیم **گفته** ...

uzb:

fars:

eng: **They tell us:** 'We are many; we will raid Nurata too' …

Comments:

> که opens the quotation and گفته closes it, like a pair of quotation marks. Inside, the speakers' own words keep their first person (هستیم, میتازیم).

bukh: **میشود** اگر رفت آمد کنند البته منع نموده **ایستاده ایم** چقدر خبرداری نموده

uzb:

fars:

eng: We **are keeping** close watch; if they come and go, they **will** certainly be stopped.

Comments:

ایستاده ایم describes an activity in progress at the time of writing. Compare the plain می form in the same sentence (منع نموده میشود, 'will be stopped'), which describes a future event.

bukh: **آمده نتوانسته** از ترس **استاده اند** تکه هم جمع شده طیار شده …

uzb:

fars:

eng: The Teke too **have gathered and are standing ready** , [but] out of fear **have been unable to come** …

Comments:

> With verbs that describe a change of state, استاده اند describes the state that results and continues: the Teke have gathered and got ready, and remain so. 'Are getting ready' would be a mistranslation.

> The same sentence has آمده نتوانسته, 'could not come': the gerund followed by توانستن.

> bukh: همین دیوانه هر روز آدمانرا زده **گشته**

> uzb: bu jinni har kuni odamlarni ubrib **yurib**

> fars:

> eng: Every day the crazy person **would constantly** beat people.

Comments:

> One meaning of the verb گشتن is 'to stroll,' 'to walk about', similar in meaning to the Uzbek yurmoq ('to walk'). However, in this case گشتن is serving first and foremost as an auxiliary verb, changing the meaning of زدن ('to strike') to indicate repeated / constant action.

bukh: مایان فقرایان را **نگاه داشته نمیتوانیم**

uzb:

fars:

eng: We **cannot hold** the subjects back.

Comments:

> The gerund comes first and توانستن second, as in Turki (Uzbek -a olmoq). Iranian Persian would put توانستن first, with a subjunctive.

> The letter comes from the Kerki uprising of 1919; see also chapter [[]].

> bukh: فقرایان بدشت و صحرا بر آمده گی **کوچیده آمده استاده اند**

> uzb:

> fars:

> eng: The subjects who had gone out to the steppe **have moved back and are staying** .

Comments:

> Two auxiliaries on one gerund: آمده (motion toward the speaker: 'back') and استاده اند (a continuing state).

> Note also بر آمده گی, the -gi participle: 'who had gone out' (chapter [[]]).

Historical-Grammatical Exploration

References

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